

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

# FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

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CHAPTER 9 · GENRE

*Genre is the promise a film makes before it starts. The shape comes after.*

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**HOLLYWOOD BLVD.**

Thelma & Louise · 1991 · 130 min · dir. Ridley Scott · written by Callie Khouri · MGM

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*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

## STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

*Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This is the last one.*

*Two sets of outlaws running for the Mexican border. Both films make the same promise inside twenty minutes: this is a crime film, and somebody is going to pay for it. *Thelma & Louise* keeps that promise to the last frame.*

*From *Dusk Till Dawn* keeps it for about an hour, reaches Mexico, and then becomes a different film altogether, with no warning and no apology. One honours the contract. The other tears it up halfway through and never looks back. Harvey Keitel is in both.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

# THELMA & LOUISE

1991 · 130 min · dir. Ridley Scott · written by Callie Khouri · MGM

Two friends leave for a weekend away from their small lives in Arkansas. One night at a roadside bar changes everything, and they keep driving.

**Why it is on the ballot.** It takes the oldest American genre promise — outlaws on the run — hands it to two women, and then keeps it with total conviction. It never cheats and never swerves, and it arrives exactly where its genre was always heading.

# BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

## IT WAS A FIRST SCRIPT, AND IT WON THE OSCAR

Callie Khouri was working in music videos when she wrote it. It was her first screenplay, and it won Best Original Screenplay. The film took six nominations in five categories, with Susan Sarandon and Geena Davis both nominated for Best Actress, plus Ridley Scott for directing, Adrian Biddle for cinematography and Thom Noble for editing.

## LOOK OUT FOR A YOUNG BRAD PITT

J.D. first went to William Baldwin, who dropped out. George Clooney, Christian Slater, Robert Downey Jr., Mark Ruffalo and Dermot Mulroney were among those who read for it. Geena Davis screen-tested with several of them and recommended Pitt.

## THE WEST IS UTAH AND CALIFORNIA

The story runs through Arkansas and Oklahoma, but almost none of it was shot there. The road belongs to rural California, Utah and Colorado, and the red-rock country is the land above the Colorado River near Moab, Utah — not the Grand Canyon it is so often taken for.

# WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

## BEFORE THEY LEAVE

### The Polaroid

The two women take a snapshot of themselves before they set off.

**Why it matters:** It is who they were before the genre got hold of them. Keep that photo in mind all the way down the road.

## THE PARKING LOT

### The promise is made

About twenty minutes in, one moment turns a weekend comedy into a crime film.

**Why it matters:** This is the contract. From this second the film owes you an outlaw story, and everything that follows pays it.

## LOUISE'S RULE

### Not through Texas

Louise refuses the direct route to Mexico because it goes through Texas, and will not say why.

**Why it matters:** The genre is pulling them south and her past is pulling against it. The route becomes the character.

## THE LAST SCENE

### Tragedy or getaway?

Surrounded at the edge of a canyon, they make a choice, and the film freezes.

**Why it matters:** The freeze-frame and the fade to white hand the decision to you. Bring your answer on Sunday.

## AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

### The ending had to be protected

A longer version was shot and exists on home video: the car falls, Hal walks to the wreck, the helicopter arrives. Scott also considered and rejected a version in which Louise pushes Thelma clear. Khouri has said Scott “really fought for that ending,” and his right to shoot it was written into his contract, because the studio kept asking for something else. Roger Ebert thought the fade to white honoured the tragedy and the credits montage took it back.

OPEN

### Harvey Keitel plays the only man on their side

Detective Hal Slocumb is the one character trying to bring them in alive. Five years later Keitel turned up in *From Dusk Till Dawn* as a preacher driving his family toward Mexico.

OPEN

### It became a national argument

*Time* put it on the cover on 24 June 1991 under the line “Why Thelma & Louise Strikes a Nerve.” Hans Zimmer scored it, with Pete Haycock’s slide guitar on the main theme.

- 01 Watch the last shot and decide: is it a tragedy, or a getaway?
- 02 At what point did you stop expecting them to turn back?
- 03 The film never changes genre. It just keeps going. Did that feel inevitable, or brave?

Where to watch

Find it here → [Thelma & Louise on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: AFI Catalog · the Academy's awards database · Slate · Time · Movie-Locations

## THE LESSON

# NOBODY CALLED IT NOIR

## A FRENCH CRITIC NAMED SOMETHING HE SAW

After the Second World War, American films that had been kept out of occupied France arrived in Paris all at once: *The Maltese Falcon*, *Double Indemnity*, *Laura*, *Murder, My Sweet*. On 28 August 1946, in *L'Écran français*, the Italian-born critic Nino Frank wrote them up under the heading of a new kind of crime picture and called the mood *film noir*. The people who made those films in Hollywood had never heard the phrase. To them they were crime pictures.

## AMERICANS MADE IT A GENRE

In the spring of 1972 the screenwriter Paul Schrader published "Notes on Film Noir" in *Film Comment*, and a generation of American directors started making noir deliberately: *Chinatown* (1974), *Body Heat* (1981), *Blade Runner* (1982). A label invented after the fact to describe a mood became a style you could aim at, with a checklist: hard shadows, voiceover, flashbacks, a doomed hero, a dangerous woman.

## THAT IS HOW GENRE WORKS

Most genres are born this way. The films come first, the name comes later, and then the name becomes a promise to the audience. Once you know the name, you know what you have been promised: a western ends in a showdown, a romantic comedy ends together, a crime film makes somebody pay.

## THREE THINGS A FILM CAN DO WITH THE PROMISE

ONE

### KEEP IT

Deliver what the genre promised, as well as it can be delivered.

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Die Hard · Heat · Thelma & Louise

TWO

### BEND IT

Stay inside the genre while playing with what you expect.

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Scream · Knives Out · Get Out

THREE

### BREAK IT

Switch genres partway through and dare you to follow.

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Psycho · Audition · From Dusk Till Dawn

A genre is really a preset of everything in this book: a structure, a clock, a point of view, a frame, a cut, a sound, a kind of character and a kind of performance, all agreed before the lights go down.

## ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

A **genre switch** is a deliberate change of genre inside one film. It works when the first promise has been kept so well that the break feels like a betrayal, and then gives you something worth being betrayed for.

## WHY THESE FILMS, AND WHY LAST

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story. This chapter is the promise made before the shape begins. So the season ends where it started, with the rules: two films, one that keeps them to the end and one that breaks them halfway through, and arrives anyway. Next time you are in a theatre, ask which one the film is doing.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: [heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com](mailto:heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com)

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Academy's awards database, Time, Slate, Roger Ebert, Box Office Mojo and Film Comment. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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